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God's Great Love for You!

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God's Great Love for You!

God loves you. Did you know that? Plain and simple. Right to the point. God loves you! And He wants to have a relationship with you!

Q. What is your initial reaction to the statement: God loves you!

It's hard to imagine that the God of the universe cares about each one of us individually, but it's true! God's love extends to each and every person ... and that includes you! There may be times when you don't feel like God loves you, or when the circumstances of your life are overwhelming and it seems as if God doesn't care, but the fact remains that God's love extends beyond all of our circumstances.

God made you in his image—you are His highest creative work! Genesis 1:27 tells us, "God created humankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them." You are precious to Him. Luke 12:7 says, "Even the hairs of your head are all numbered. Do not be afraid; you are more valuable than many sparrows." And God is going to love you forever! Psalm 13:5 declares, "I trust in your faithfulness. May I rejoice because of your deliverance!"

Q. As you consider the three verses above, which one speaks to you most at this time in your life?

Q. Which verse is most difficult for you to embrace?

Q. Why is it difficult for you to embrace it?

God's love for you isn't dependent upon your performance for Him. God's love for you flows out of His very nature. Psalm 119:76 says, "May your loyal love console me, as you promised your servant." Jeremiah 31:3 reminds us, "In a far-off land the Lord will manifest himself to them. He will say to them, 'I have loved you with an everlasting love.'"

Q. What do the verses in Psalm 119 and Jeremiah 3 say about God's love?

Q. What does it mean to you that God's love is loyal and everlasting?

Q. Has there ever been a time in your life when you felt as though you were beyond God's love or you doubted His love for you? Do you know someone who feels they are beyond God's love?

Q. Are there times in your own life, or do you see it in someone you know, when you try to earn God's love? What kinds of things do you do? How does it make you feel? Does it work?

God is love. God's love is so great that He gave his only Son to bring us into a relationship with Him. God's love not only encompasses the world, but embraces each of us personally and intimately.

First John 4:9-10 explains: "By this the love of God is revealed in us: that God has sent his one and only Son into the world so that we may live through him. In this is love: not that we have loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the atoning sacrifice for our sins."

In *The Nature of God's Great Love*, Robert Wells writes, "The sad truth is that even though many people today have heard that God loves them, they simply don't believe it. They just cannot understand or comprehend the reality of God's love in their lives. They can't grasp something they cannot see. They haven't learned how to recognize it and experience it and therefore they don't know how to embrace it, nurture it, grow in it, or truly enjoy it. And without knowing and realizing that God loves us we cannot possibly have hope in our lives. We will not be aware of the purpose or the meaning that God wants us to have concerning our lives. God wants us to know a lot about him, but the most important thing that he wants us to know about him is the tremendous and awesome love that he has for each and every one of us. That is why the apostle John could write in 1 John 4:8, 'The person who does not love does not know God, because God is love'" (<http://robertwells.tripod.com/godislove.html>).

God's love is not based upon attraction or performance. It is totally sacrificial and unselfish.

Q. Has there ever been a time in your life when you have truly felt God's love? When? Or if not, what do you think it might feel like to be totally wrapped up in God's love?

Are you measuring God's love for you by your present circumstances—either good or bad? The truth is your circumstances are always changing because of daily experiences, relationships, and choices. Maybe you feel as though God is not

answering your prayers. God is answering your prayers, but in His way and in His time. His great love for you sees the big picture of your life. You can't do anything to get God to stop loving you!

Q. On a scale of 1 to 10, how much do you feel God's love? In reality, how much love does God have for you?

Not one of us knows why God loves us. We just can see that God's love is radically different from ours. It is not based upon attraction or performance. It is totally sacrificial and unselfish. Jesus compared God's love with the love of a perfect father. A good father wants the best for his children, sacrifices for them, and provides for them. And, in their best interests, he also disciplines them. John 1:12 tells us, "But to all who have received him—those who believe in his name—he has given the right to become God's children." God created you to have life that is flooded with meaning and purpose.

You may be thinking, "Yes, I know that God is love, and that I am his creation, but my sin is too great, I've failed God too many times. I've broken too promises. I've made too many poor choices. I've walked away from God more times than I can count." But the good news is that God never says, "That's it, no more love! I've had it with you!" God's everlasting love means that you can't do anything to get God to stop loving you!

Robert Wells puts it this way, "God hates our sin, but even as we are sinning he still loves us with that perfect unconditional love. It is a love that is simply beyond the comprehension of the human mind."

Man's inability to understand God's great love is probably best described by Paul in Ephesians 3:19, "a love which surpasses all knowledge."

In Romans 8:38–39, Paul tells us, "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, nor angels nor heavenly rulers, nor things that are present, nor things to come, nor powers, nor height, nor depth, nor anything else in creation will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord."

Q. What are some of the things that might keep people from experiencing God's love?

Experiencing God's love requires that you place your life in God's hands. You need to ask forgiveness of your sins and then ask God to come into your life. If you truly ask God to come into your life and give you guidance, He will! Ask Him to show you the path that He wants you to take and ask Him to help you get started.

Tell Him that you want to trust Him completely with your life and that you want Him to take the lead as you live your life.

Are there times when your life just feels empty? Nothing you have tried satisfies the inner void you feel? God can fill that void and change you in a moment. He created you to have life that is flooded with meaning and purpose.

Jesus said: "The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come so that they may have life, and may have it abundantly." —John 10:10.

Perhaps things are going well for you in life, but you are restless or lack peace. You realize that you are separated from God's love and forgiveness and you fear His judgment.

Jesus also said: "Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you; I do not give it to you as the world does. Do not let your hearts be distressed or lacking in courage." —John 14:27.

So whether you are simply tired of a life of empty pursuits or are troubled by a lack of peace, the answer still comes down to having a relationship with God through Jesus Christ.

When you put your trust in Jesus Christ, God will forgive you of all your sins—past, present, and future. You will become His child. He will give you purpose and meaning in life on earth. All of God's children have the promise of eternal life with Him. God's love is not based on how good you are or how you feel, it is grounded in His nature of love. His love is part of who He is.

Q. Have you put your life in God's hands? When? Or why not? What will it take for you to let God into your life?

Application

Q. What key idea about God's love do you want to remember from this lesson?

Take some time right now to sit in God's presence. Ask Him to fill the empty places in your life with Himself. Ask Him to allow you to experience His love.